

The Living Wild — Product Review

How a Drive-Through Photography Exhibition Became One of Dubai's Most Innovative Digital Wildlife Experiences

Product: The Living Wild — Interactive Wildlife Gallery App
Client: Al Marmoom Desert Conservation Reserve, Dubai, UAE
Exhibition: Drive-Through Photography Exhibition by Ali Bin Thalith
Live Period: January 22 — February 9, 2026 (19 days)
Platform: Mobile-first Progressive Web Application

The Challenge

The Al Marmoom Desert Conservation Reserve wanted something more than a traditional photography exhibition. The concept was ambitious: a drive-through experience across the desert where visitors would encounter 24 stunning wildlife photographs, each representing a species native to the Arabian desert. But the question was — how do you turn a physical, passive viewing experience into something interactive, educational, and memorable in the age of smartphones?

The answer was The Living Wild.

The Product

The Living Wild is a mobile-first web application that served as the digital companion to the physical exhibition. Rather than simply displaying photographs in a gallery app, the team built something far more layered: a gamified discovery platform that combined QR code scanning, bilingual video content, augmented reality, AI-powered wildlife education, and competitive leaderboards — all accessible instantly from a mobile browser without any app download.

The result was an app that didn't just complement the exhibition — it transformed it.

Design Decision #1: Progressive Web App Over Native App

Why it worked — and the data proves it

The most consequential technical decision was building The Living Wild as a progressive web app rather than a native iOS/Android application. For a 19-day exhibition in the desert, asking visitors to open the App Store, search for an app, download it, and create an account would have been a massive friction point. Instead, visitors simply scanned a QR code and the app loaded instantly in their browser.

The data tells the story:

874 unique visitors engaged with the app — 179 registered users plus 695 guest sessions
Zero download barrier meant visitors could start interacting within seconds of arriving

The guest-to-registered ratio (79% guests, 21% registered) confirms that most visitors wanted instant access without commitment — and the PWA approach gave them exactly that

If this had been a native app, it's reasonable to estimate that 70-80% of those 695 guest sessions would never have happened. That's potentially 500+ visitors who would have driven through the exhibition without any digital engagement at all. The PWA decision alone may have tripled the app's effective reach.

Design Decision #2: QR Codes as the Bridge Between Physical and Digital

The feature that generated 110,817 interactions

Each of the 24 animal exhibits along the drive route had a unique QR code. When visitors scanned it with their phone's camera, the corresponding animal was unlocked in their digital gallery. This simple mechanic created the app's single most-used feature — and it wasn't even close.

The numbers are staggering:

110,817 total QR scans across the 19-day exhibition

599 unique scanners — meaning QR engagement extended well beyond just registered users

Average of ~185 scans per unique scanner — indicating visitors were scanning multiple animals, often repeatedly

The top 9 animals accounted for over 95,000 scans, showing that the QR system was heavily used throughout the exhibition route

What made this design brilliant was the format: `TLW-{animalId}-{token}`. It was simple enough to be instantly reliable (no complex URLs or deep links) while incorporating a security token to prevent spoofing. Visitors didn't need to open the app first, navigate to a scanner, or fumble with camera permissions — they just pointed their phone's native camera at the code and the magic happened.

The QR system also created a natural feedback loop: scan a code, see an animal unlock in your gallery, feel the satisfaction of discovery, and want to scan the next one. It turned a drive-through exhibition into a treasure hunt.

Most popular exhibits by QR scanner

Animal	Scans	Likely Position
Dorcas Gazelle	19,555	Near entrance
Iraqi Sandgrouse	18,324	Early route
Ruppell's Fox	12,847	Early-mid route
Water Rail	11,110	Mid route
Yellow Wagtail	10,621	Mid route

The scan drop-off pattern (from 19,555 for the first animal to 49 for the last) actually provides valuable insight into visitor behavior along the drive route — data that would have been impossible to collect without the app.

Design Decision #3: Gamification That Actually Worked

14 completionists, 82 active video watchers, and a leaderboard that drove real behavior

Gamification is one of the most overused and underdelivered concepts in app design. Most implementations feel forced — arbitrary points, meaningless badges, leaderboards nobody

checks. The Living Wild avoided all of these pitfalls by tying gamification directly to the exhibition's core purpose: discovering wildlife.

How the gamification worked:

Animals started locked in the gallery (shown grayed out with a lock icon)

Scanning a QR code at the physical exhibit unlocked the animal

Watching the educational video earned points

A progress bar showed how many of the 24 animals had been discovered

A leaderboard ranked users by total points

The data shows this wasn't just a gimmick:

14 users (8% of registered) were motivated enough to discover and watch all 24 animals — achieving a perfect 24/24 score

The top 20 users all watched 22 or more animals, showing deep sustained engagement

82 users (46% of registered) watched at least one video

The average active user watched 9 animals — meaning once people started engaging, they typically watched more than a third of the collection

1,542 video plays with a 68% watch-through rate (watched for 10+ seconds) — far above typical short-form video retention

The gamification worked because it was intrinsically motivated. The reward for scanning wasn't an arbitrary badge — it was seeing a beautiful wildlife photograph come to life with video and AR. The leaderboard wasn't competing for nothing — it was a measure of genuine exploration. The progress bar wasn't tracking meaningless metrics — it was tracking a real journey through 24 desert species.

The completionists tell the real story:

Name	Animals Watched	Score
Ameen Abdu Rahim	24/24	24
Majbah Mishu	24/24	24
Abdullah Al Tamimi	24/24	24
Anoop Mohamed Basheer	24/24	24

Rashedul Kabir	24/24	24
Ali Mohammed Al Danhani	24/24	24
Najlaa Al Abdouli	24/24	24
And 7 more...	24/24	24

These 14 people didn't just glance at the exhibition. They engaged with every single animal, watched every video, and completed the entire collection. For a short-term outdoor exhibition, this level of dedication is remarkable.

Design Decision #4: Bilingual Support Done Right

Not just translation — true cultural integration

Dubai's population is extraordinarily diverse, and an exhibition celebrating the UAE's natural heritage needed to speak to both Arabic and English audiences authentically. The Living Wild didn't take the common shortcut of machine-translating the UI and calling it done. Instead, it implemented bilingual support at every layer:

Full RTL (right-to-left) layout for Arabic — not just flipped text, but properly mirrored navigation, card layouts, and button placement

Separate video content in both English and Arabic — 48 videos total (24 animals x 2 languages)

AI wildlife guide responses in both languages — questions asked in Arabic received Arabic answers, and vice versa

Language selection as the very first interaction on the landing page — respecting the user's preference from the start

This wasn't a superficial translation layer bolted onto an English app. It was a genuinely dual-language experience that treated Arabic as a first-class citizen. For an exhibition in the UAE celebrating local wildlife, this level of cultural respect

was essential — and the visitor engagement numbers suggest it paid off. With 179 registered users representing Arabic, South Asian, and Western names on the leaderboard, the app clearly reached across Dubai's multicultural population.

Design Decision #5: Video Strategy — Manual Play Was the Right Call

1,542 plays and 68% completion without forcing a single autoplay

In a world where every app wants to autoplay video at you, The Living Wild made a deliberately different choice for its animal videos: manual play only. This wasn't a technical limitation — the intro video autoplays with muted audio. It was a conscious UX decision, and the data validates it.

Why manual play was smart:

1. Context matters. Visitors were in vehicles driving through a desert. Sudden audio blaring from their phone would have been jarring and annoying. Manual play respected the physical environment.

2. Quality over quantity. The 68% watch-through rate (1,050 watched for 10+ seconds out of 1,542 plays) is exceptionally strong. When people chose to press play, they actually watched. Autoplay typically drives much lower completion rates because viewers didn't actively choose to engage.

3. Battery and data consideration. An outdoor desert exhibition means visitors are away from charging, likely on mobile data. Not autoplaying 48 video files respected these practical constraints.

The video engagement was remarkably even across animals:

The most-watched animal (Little Grebe, 145 plays) was only ~3.5x the least-watched (Dorcas Gazelle, 42 plays)

Compare this to QR scans where the top animal had 400x the scans of the bottom one

This even distribution suggests that video engagement was driven by genuine interest rather than position on the route

The intro video, by contrast, was designed to autoplay with muted audio and a prominent gold-glowing unmute button. This was the right call for an onboarding moment that needed to capture attention and set the mood. The differentiation between "intro autoplay" and "content manual play" showed sophisticated UX thinking.

Design Decision #6: Augmented Reality as a Wow Factor

507 AR experiences launched from a single button tap

AR in web apps is still an emerging technology, and many implementations fail because they require separate app downloads, complex setup, or confusing permissions flows. The Living Wild integrated AR through Zappar/Mattercraft WebXR, accessible through a single "Enter AR" button on each animal's detail page. One tap, and the animal appeared in 3D in the visitor's actual desert surroundings.

The 507 total AR views across all 24 animals

Little Grebe led with 107 AR views (21% of all AR views) — the first animal visitors encountered, and likely the point where most people discovered the feature

33% of video watchers also tried AR — a strong cross-feature engagement rate

Every single animal had at least some AR views (minimum: White-tailed Lapwing with 2), showing the feature was discovered and used across the entire collection

507 AR sessions is a meaningful number for an emerging technology at a 19-day exhibition. It represents genuine curiosity and delight — people don't launch AR experiences by accident. The fact that AR was available for all 24 animals (not just a select few) meant that visitors who enjoyed the first AR experience could keep exploring, contributing to the engagement numbers.

The one-button-tap integration was crucial. If AR had required a separate app, a QR scan, or even a multi-step setup, the adoption would have been a fraction of 507.

Design Decision #7: AI Wildlife Guide — Education on Demand

Turning a gallery app into an interactive learning platform

Perhaps the most forward-thinking feature was the AI-powered wildlife guide, built on GPT-4o-mini through OpenAI. From any animal's detail page, visitors could ask questions like "What does the Arabian Oryx eat?" or "Where does the Desert Monitor live?" and receive immediate, contextually relevant answers in either English or Arabic.

This feature transformed The Living Wild from a consumption-only media app into an interactive educational tool. Visitors weren't limited to the pre-recorded video content — they could follow their own curiosity in real-time. A child asking "Is the Hedgehog dangerous?" would get a different, personalized answer than an adult asking "What is the conservation status of the Houbara Bustard?"

For an exhibition hosted by a conservation reserve, this educational dimension was mission-critical. The Al Marmoom reserve exists to protect these species, and the AI guide gave visitors the tools to develop genuine understanding and appreciation — not just passive recognition.

Design Decision #8: Guest Access Without Registration Barriers

How respecting visitor autonomy quadrupled the audience

The Living Wild allowed full app access without requiring registration. Visitors could scan QR codes, browse the gallery, watch videos, try AR, and ask the AI guide questions — all without creating an account.

Registration was optional, incentivized through the gamification features (progress tracking, leaderboard, saved progress).

This was arguably the most important UX decision in the entire app:

That means 79% of all app users would have been lost if registration were mandatory

The 21% who did register did so voluntarily, meaning they were genuinely engaged and their data was higher quality

Many apps make the mistake of gating everything behind registration, believing it maximizes "conversions." In reality, for a short-term exhibition where visitors have 30 seconds of patience, mandatory registration would have been catastrophic for engagement. The Living Wild understood that reach matters more than registration — and the numbers prove it.

The optional registration also meant the 51 Parkers leads captured through the separate lead form were genuinely interested prospects, not people who checked a box just to access the app.

Design Decision #9: The Visual Identity — Desert Elegance

A design that framed the photography without competing with it

The visual design of The Living Wild used a carefully chosen desert palette:

Gold (#b97d42) — for primary actions, accents, and the mute button glow

Dark Brown (#30221b) — for backgrounds, creating depth and focus

Cream (#fef3dc) — for text and light surfaces

Combined with the custom Dubai font family, the app had a premium, location-appropriate feel that honored both the UAE setting and Ali Bin Thalith's photography. The dark backgrounds were essential — they made the vivid wildlife photographs the visual focal point, exactly as they should be in a photography exhibition.

The design also used Framer Motion animations for page transitions and UI interactions, adding a layer of polish that made the app feel native rather than web-based. Small details like the gradient overlays on the intro video, the progress bar animations, and the card reveal effects all contributed to an experience that felt considered and complete.

Design Decision #10: Real-Time Admin Analytics

Operational intelligence that powered daily decisions

The built-in admin dashboard wasn't a nice-to-have — it was a strategic tool that gave exhibition staff live visibility into visitor engagement. The admin panel provided:

Real-time signup tracking — staff could see exactly how many people were registering each day

Per-animal engagement data — identifying which exhibits were most and least popular

Activity type breakdowns — understanding the ratio of QR scans to video watches to AR views

Parkers campaign monitoring — tracking lead capture in real-time during the promotional partnership

CSV export — enabling stakeholder reporting without external analytics tools

The peak activity hours data revealed that 73,438 activities (64% of all engagement) occurred between 10 PM and 11 PM UAE time. This insight alone is invaluable — it confirmed that the exhibition's evening hours were by far the most popular, which could inform staffing, lighting, and operational decisions for future events.

The login-by-date data showed two distinct engagement surges (Jan 29-31 and Feb 6-8), likely corresponding to promotional campaigns or weekend traffic. This kind of real-time feedback allowed the exhibition team to understand what was working and adjust their approach mid-run.

The Numbers That Matter Most

Metric	Value	What It Means
874+ unique visitors	PWA + guest access	Frictionless entry maximized reach
110,817 QR scans	QR-driven discovery	Physical-digital bridge created massive engagement

599 unique scanners	Beyond registered users	QR engagement reached guests and walk-ups
1,542 video plays	Manual play strategy	Every play was an intentional choice
68% watch-through	Content quality	People who pressed play actually watched
507 AR views	One-tap integration	Emerging tech adopted at meaningful scale
14 completionists	Gamification that worked	Real motivation, not gimmicks
9.0 avg videos/user	Sustained engagement	Users explored broadly, not superficially
51 leads captured	Optional conversion	High-quality, voluntarily submitted
28% lead conversion	Parkers campaign	Excellent for a non-mandatory promotional tie-in

Peak Engagement Pattern

The activity-by-hour data paints a vivid picture of visitor behavior:

UAE Time	Activity Count	% of Total
2:00 AM (10 PM UTC)	73,438	64.3%
12:00 AM (8 PM UTC)	12,968	11.4%
1:00 AM (9 PM UTC)	10,452	9.2%
6:00 PM (2 PM UTC)	3,215	2.8%

The overwhelming dominance of late-evening activity makes perfect sense for a desert exhibition — visitors came during the cooler evening and nighttime hours. The app was ready for them whenever they arrived, with no "business hours" limitations. This 24/7 availability is another advantage of the PWA approach over staffed or scheduled experiences.

What Made The Living Wild Special

Most exhibition apps fall into one of two traps: they're either too simple (a static gallery with some text) or too complex (requiring downloads, accounts, tutorials). The Living Wild threaded the needle perfectly. It was simple enough that a visitor scanning their first QR code could immediately understand what the app did. No onboarding tutorial, no

complex navigation, no required permissions. Point camera at code. Animal unlocks. Watch video. Try AR. Done.

It was deep enough that engaged visitors could spend hours exploring all 24 animals, watching videos in two languages, experiencing AR, asking the AI guide detailed questions, and climbing the leaderboard. The 14 completionists prove that depth was there for those who wanted it.

It was respectful enough that it never forced registration, never autoplayed videos at inappropriate moments, never spammed notifications, and always let the visitor control their own pace of discovery. In an era of attention-grabbing dark patterns, this restraint was both refreshing and effective.

And critically, it was measurable. Every QR scan, every video play, every AR view, every registration was tracked and available in real-time through the admin dashboard. The exhibition team didn't have to guess whether the app was working — they could see it in the data, every single day.

Verdict

The Living Wild is a case study in how technology should serve an experience rather than dominate it. The app didn't try to replace the physical exhibition — it elevated it. It turned passive viewing into active discovery, turned photographs into multimedia experiences, and turned a one-time visit into a journey of exploration across 24 species of Arabian desert wildlife.

With 874+ unique visitors, 110,817 QR interactions, 1,542 video plays, 507 AR experiences, and 14 dedicated completionists over just 19 days, The Living Wild delivered

measurable impact at every level.
More importantly, it did so while
respecting its visitors' time,
attention, and autonomy.

For the Al Marmoom Desert
Conservation Reserve, The Living
Wild proved that a photography
exhibition can be so much more
than photographs on walls — or in
this case, photographs in the
desert. It can be a platform for
education, engagement, and
genuine connection with the
natural world.

And that's exactly what
conservation needs.

*Product review written March 31, 2026
Based on production analytics data
from the 19-day exhibition period
All metrics sourced from The Living
Wild production database*